

Sorting through some Core Chaos

So many platforms, processors, chipsets, motherboards! Someone had to make things clear. It might as well be me!

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It was time for another major upgrade that involved changing my faithful Intel P45 chipset P5Q3 motherboard and Core 2 Duo E8400 processor. I packed my bags and headed off to Lamington Road to see what I could find.

The processor and motherboard market has been heating up. There's a wider choice now and at the same time, more confusion with new sockets and chipsets cropping up. To those oblivious to the developments, Intel has moved to two major sockets – LGA1366 and LGA1156; the LGA1366 for the top of the line Core i7 processors and the LGA1156 for the Core i5 and Core i3 processors.

I walked into a slightly fancy store and just out of curiosity, asked for the fastest Core i7 processor – the i7 975. They said that no one really went for those expensive processors. The only one remotely available was the slower 3.2 GHz i7 965 priced at Rs. 53,000, which is way too high. The cheapest Core i7 920 was priced at a Rs. 14,300, which is still quite high for most of us. A decent motherboard to go along with it would cost another Rs. 10,000 at least. MSI's X58-Pro priced at around Rs. 11,300 was available. I remember it for its good value for money. Biostar too, had a few offerings around this price range. The shopkeeper even showed me the Gigabyte EX58 EXTREME, a top-end board for some Rs. 21,000. I wasn't exactly looking for a Rs. 75,000 processor-motherboard combination though.

I focussed on the Intel Core i5 range and AMD's new Phenom. Prices for the cheapest Core i5 were a little more reassuring. The Core i5 750 was priced at Rs.

9,900 bundled with a decent VFM board such as the Gigabyte GA-P55M-UD2 (Rs. 6,200) would be a solid base to build a system on. Few shopkeepers tried to sell me cheap AMD combos as well. An AMD processor with a cheap board is bundled as part of the deal. I wasn't interested in those. Instead, I asked around for the AMD Phenom x4 Black Edition 955 and the 965. They were around Rs. 8,200 and Rs. 9,200 respectively. The Black Edition would let me overclock the processor over the 4-GHz mark.

I made a note of the models and asked for some more motherboard options, preferably based on the AMD 785G chipset or the 790FX chipset. Some of the shopkeepers had no clue of the chipsets, so I looked through some of the boxes they showed me. The best and also the costliest offerings were from ASUS – the M4A79T Deluxe and the Crosshair III Formula both based on the 790FX chipset and both pretty expensive – prices were between Rs. 12,800 and Rs. 13,800. The MSI 790FX-GD70 was of a similar range but the price a considerably lower Rs. 9,800. The AMD 785G is a great alternative and I found some decent models from Gigabyte and ASUS for the same. The Gigabyte MA785GM-US2H was very cheap at just Rs. 4,500 and it even had an HDMI port that makes it perfect for an HTPC. The ASUS M4A78STD-V-EVO was priced at Rs. 6,500 and it supported CrossFire support that could help future proof my system. The option of going with the NVIDIA nForce platform is also present. The options for the AMD platform are on the 780a SLI platform. This is a slightly older platform, but it's what formed the top line of boards. Boards from ASUS for example can be found between the Rs. 8,000 and Rs. 11,000 mark. Those looking for cheaper

boards for HTPCs have to look at the GeForce 8200 and 8300. Those boards are difficult to find, but they should be under Rs. 7,000. Look for models from ZOTAC and XFX.

If you're building with the least investment, the Athlon II X2 245 priced at around Rs. 3,000 is the way to go. It makes good sense when bundled with an AMD 785G powered motherboard. It will play HD content and also some basic games. For those looking for more power, there is the new Athlon II X4 630 for Rs. 5,100 that happens to be a quad-core. If you're looking an Intel setup, you won't have problems finding the Core 2 Duo E7500 for around Rs. 5,500. The more powerful Core 2 Q8400 is more affordable as well. Those looking for a system to render a lot of stuff should go for it. I found it for Rs. 8,500. Intel's LGA775 processors are now more or less at par in pricing with their AMD counterparts. Generally, the recommended boards from my end for the Core 2 series are based on the P45 chipset. The P5Q series from ASUS and the EP45 range from Gigabyte start from around the Rs. 8,000 mark and go way beyond Rs. 15,000. If you want something a little cheaper, the MSI P45 Neo3 is available for Rs. 7,000.

It was a fun trip. There are so many choices available today, it's ridiculous and there's a solution for every need. I only wish the Core i7 processors drop in price and so do the X58 boards. The performance jump is huge and it would be nice to get my hands on it. **d**

